

cropping, rotating and resizing, without the need for a PC! None of the other printers had this. It also featured an automatic print head alignment function, where you just click 'align print head', and it does it for you.

The Canon printers had the worst ink status display as we had to restart our PCs to get an updated report. In most of the other cases, simply restarting the ink monitor did the trick. The point to note is that except for the Lexmark, none of them showed it in real time.

The only other printer with an LCD (B&W) was the Epson Photo R310, and you could neither see nor edit photos on it. Although it did not feature automatic print head aligning, it did have memory card slots. The Canon Pixma iP4000 did indeed have automatic alignment, but it lacked the colour screen and a memory card reader, which is strange considering this printer costs Rs 11,000, and is being touted as a photo printer!

One really innovative and unique feature of the Canon printers in this segment was dual paper feed; they can take papers from the top or from the bottom. This effectively doubles print capacity to 300 sheets. This lets you segregate different types of paper: you can put your photo papers at the bottom and regular papers at the top. Then, depending on your printing needs, you can use the dedicated button to select the paper source. This feature is very useful if you want to print in large quantities, as you can load up both trays and when one finishes you switch to printing from the other tray while the first one gets refilled!

The Canon iP3000, iP4000 and the Epson Photo R310 all supported CD/DVD printing.

Performance

The printers underwent the same test process as home printers. In pure text printing speed, the Canons were miles ahead of all others, with iP2000 printing the document in just seven seconds. The second-fastest was

iP1500 at nine seconds, while iP4000 and 3000 took 12 and 13.5 seconds each. The fastest non-Canon printer was HP 5748 at 16 seconds. The Epson R210 and R310 clocked 49.7 and 46 seconds each. The feature-rich Lexmark P915 turned out to be slowest with 45.1 seconds.

In the quality of text prints, it was all Canon again, with the Pixma 3000 and 4000 giving us some of the crispest printouts we have seen.

Since this is the office/photo printing category, we assumed that the combi-doc would have a significant role to play, and promptly put the printers through their paces. It was all Canon yet again, with the top two being the iP4000 with 27 seconds and the iP3000 with 31.1 seconds. The third-fastest was the HP 5748 with 47.4 seconds—a full 16 seconds slower.

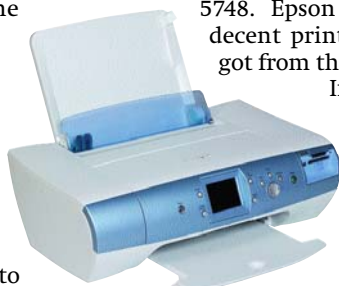
In terms of quality of the combi-doc, the iP4000 and iP3000 tied for the top spot, with the iP2000 coming in a very close third.

The Lexmark was close to the Canons in terms of quality, and was closely followed by the HP 5748. Epson turned out some decent printouts, but those we got from the others were better.

If you print lots of official reports, trend charts, graphs and the like, the iP3000 and 4000 will do a smashing job.

Since this section is for photo printers as well, we gave significant weightage to printing photos, both in terms of quality and speed. No surprises again: the Pixmas shone, and the fastest photo printout was shot out by the Canon iP3000 in 177 seconds. This was followed closely by the iP4000 with 210 seconds. The third-fastest was the Lexmark P915 with 314 seconds. The HP 5748 took 463 seconds, with the Epsoms bringing up the rear yet again with the R210 and R310 printing the photo in 488 and 523 seconds respectively.

In terms of quality, the Canon iP3000 won by a hairsbreadth, with the Lexmark P915 and Canon iP4000 tying for second position. The iP2000 came in third, beaten by the iP4000 by just a fraction.



Lexmark P915

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